



Megatherium

meg-ah-THEER-ee-um



- **When** 5 million–10,000 years ago (Late Neogene)
- **Fossil location** S. America
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 20 ft (6 m)
- **Diet** Plants

When *Megatherium* walked upright it was almost twice the height of an elephant. It was covered with thick, shaggy hair, under which were bony plates that formed a kind of armor. The teeth were blunt for mashing leaves, but some experts think *Megatherium*

may have also used its claws to scavenge on dead meat or even kill for food.



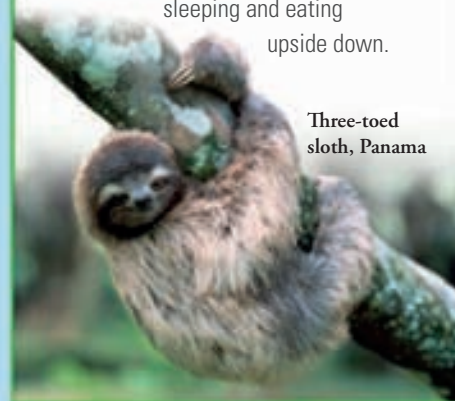
Hip bone

▼ **MEGA CLAWS** *Megatherium* had enormous, curved claws that it used to grasp branches and fight predators. It could not place its feet flat on the ground—instead, it walked on the sides of its feet, with the claws turned inward.

▲ **MEGATHERIUM'S** hip bones were especially strong. They supported the weight of the huge body when the animal stood upright. The stout tail also helped, acting as a prop.

LIVING RELATIVE

Modern sloths appear to be the laziest animals on Earth, sleeping up to 18 hours a day and moving with amazing slowness when awake. Unlike *Megatherium*, today's sloths spend their lives hanging upside down from trees. They cling to branches with long arms and hooked claws, even sleeping and eating upside down.



Three-toed sloth, Panama

